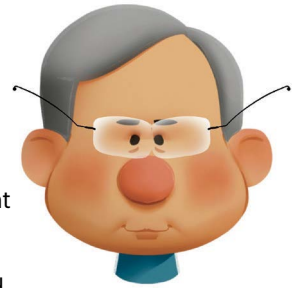
IN THE DARK



Nothing exposes a creaking system quite like a VIP embarrassment. On June 11, a BJP event in Jaipur celebrating 12 years of the Modi government was repeatedly knocked off script by power cuts. Union minister **Ashwini Vaishnaw** and Rajasthan power minister Heera Lal Nagar were left waiting in the dark as power went off three times. Vaishnaw eventually pressed on with mobile phone torches, a fitting visual for a state still struggling to keep the lights on. The government, as usual, moved quickly against the small fry, suspending an electrician and an assistant engineer.

GIFT GRILLING



Rashtriya Janata Dal patriarch Lalu Prasad Yadav rang in his 78th birthday on June 11, but the highlight of the celebrations was wife and ex-CM **Rabri Devi** gifting Bhojpuri singer Chhotu Chhalia her *kangan* for an inspired performance. But that happy moment stood marred two days later, when JD(U) legislative council whip Neeraj Kumar wrote to the Economic Offences Unit and the omnipresent ED, seeking an 'independent valuation' of the bracelet, and insinuating a benami angle to the 'gift'. RJD MLC Sunil Singh dismissed the allegations, insisting it was "artificial metal" and remarking that all that glitters is not gold. Over to the agencies now.

WRONG BAR CODE



A film shoot in Haridwar recently ran into a distinctly local reality check. *Gunmaaster G9*, starring **Emraan Hashmi**, had a set with a signboard reading 'Cafe & Bar'. Now, 'bar', even a fictitious one, was enough to bring out the saffron trolls and other protesters in what is one of Hinduism's holiest towns. Videos of heated exchanges between locals and the film crew soon surfaced on social media, turning a movie prop into a public controversy. Finally, the filmmakers caved in: the word 'bar' was removed from the signboard. That done, the shoot continued in Haridwar and nearby Dehradun.

Kaushik Deka* with *Avaneesh Mishra, Prasad Nichenametla* and *Amitabh Srivastava

ECO WATCH

TIGER ALERTS
AI TO THE RESCUE

By **Jumana Shah**

As India's tiger population expands beyond protected reserves, wildlife managers are turning to artificial intelligence to prevent deadly encounters—the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) recorded 418 human deaths nationwide (2020-'25) due to tiger attacks. An experiment is now under way at the Pench tiger landscape, where an AI-driven Tiger Alert System, developed by Maharashtra government's tech arm MARVEL, uses bioacoustics to detect alarm calls from prey species and warn villages of big cat movement.

Acoustic sensors installed in forests analyse sounds and calls of species such as deer and langurs in real time and send alerts to forest officials and local communities when a tiger is nearby.

Recent incidents have underscored the challenge. Madhya Pradesh's Bandhavgarh Tiger Reserve alone has seen at least five fatal tiger attacks in the past two months. The incidents have triggered protests and renewed demands for stronger conflict-mitigation measures.

Experts say the rise in encounters is partly a consequence of India's conservation success. Tiger numbers have recovered significantly over the past two decades, leading to dispersal into buffer forests, revenue lands and other human-dominated areas. While officials stress that technology alone cannot prevent conflict, the Pench project does point to a shift in conservation strategy—from responding to attacks to predicting and preventing them.



PTI